setting a world record in this regard). Dr. Derow analyzed it and said it was calcium oxalate dihydrate. This was good in one respect: It was a slow-growing variety of stone and was not likely to grow too large to be passed. It was bad in another respect: It was a jagged variety of stone and the most painful of the different kinds. 3

11

By this time, my expertise had reached the point where writing was virtually painless. On February 4, 1951, I began a story called "Nobody Here but—" and, without visible effort, I finished its 5,000 words in two days.

I was hoping I might place it in some slick magazine. This was not an entirely new ambition of mine. It antedated even Heinlein's appearance in The Saturday Evening Post. When we were living in Wingate Hall, I had written a "mainstream" romantic short story I had intended for Collier's but had never managed to sell anywhere.

"Flesh and Metal" was science fiction, but it had an element of romance, and I had vainly tried to sell it to the slicks before it went to Amazing. And now "Nobody Here but—" was submitted to the slicks, but uselessly.

On February 8,1 received a request from a magazine that was not a pulp. It was The Writer, which, as its name implies, is an instructional

3 And by now the American retreat in Korea had come to an end and we were beginning to jab northward again.

and inspirational magazine for beginning writers, and which then paid $10 an article. What's more, it didn't want a story, but a nonfiction piece, only 2,000 words long, on science fiction.

I obliged and took the article in on February 23, since The Writer had its offices in downtown Boston. That gave me the occasion to meet Abe Burack, the editor, loud-voiced, aggressive, very opinionated, full of advice on anything and everything—and very kindhearted.

He took my article, which I called "Other Worlds to Conquer." It was the first nonfiction piece I ever did for a paying market—though not a very-much-paying market.

Meanwhile, Greenberg, having done I, Robot, offered to do the various stories of the Foundation series in three volumes. I was more than willing. I was